4.2 Great Awakening and Enlightenment

Have you ever listened to someone who made you think about a familiar topic in a new way? Something like that happened to colonists in the early 1700s and reawakened their dedication to religion.

MAIN IDEA The Enlightenment, emphasizing reason, and the Great Awakening, a religious renewal, helped shape colonial thought.

THE GREAT AWAKENING

You probably remember that many of the first colonists came to America to seek religious freedom. But once they'd achieved it, they began to focus on the material concerns of everyday life. People concentrated on their work and their homes. As a result, by the early 1700s, people's passion for religion had begun to die down. Some even stopped going to church regularly.

Many Protestant ministers feared that colonists were losing sight of the importance of God. In an effort to inspire people to recommit to their spiritual beliefs, these ministers gave stirring—and sometimes frightening—sermons during a series of religious revivals known as the **Great Awakening**.

One of the most effective of these ministers was **Jonathan Edwards** of Massachusetts. In 1734, he began preaching sermons on **salvation**, or the deliverance from sin. In his most famous sermon, "Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God," Edwards compared his listeners to spiders. God, he said, held them by a string over the fires of hell. If they failed to seek salvation, he warned, God would simply let go of the string.

Another minister, **George Whitefield**, came from Britain to preach salvation to the colonists. With his theatrical gestures and thundering words, he appealed to people's emotions and brought them to tears. Some even fainted.

The revivals of the Great Awakening changed how people viewed religion and morality. People began to believe they did not need church officials to

A Ray of Hope

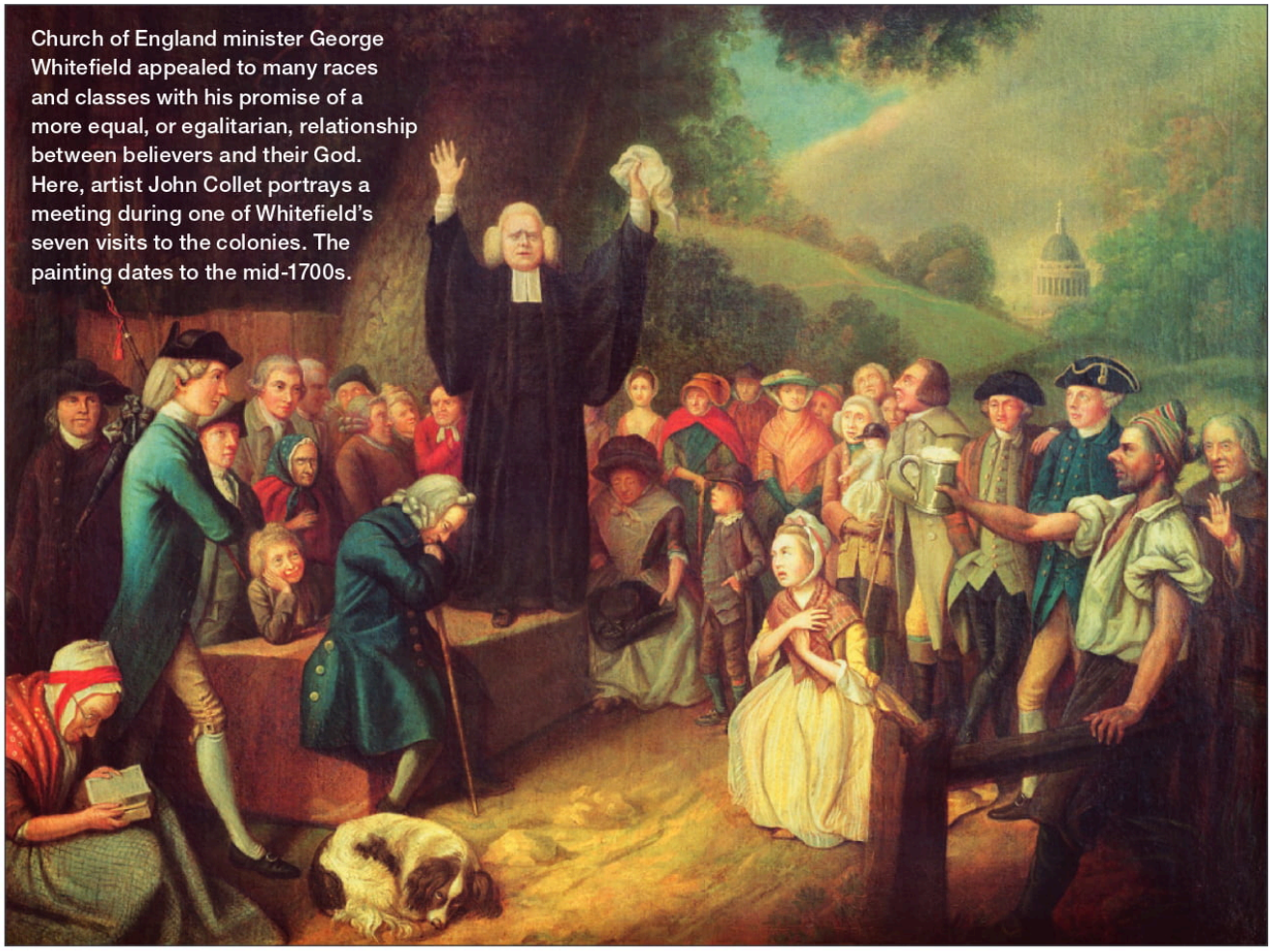
Jonathan Edwards delivered "Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God" in 1741 to a congregation in Connecticut. Unlike George Whitefield, Edwards spoke in a quiet voice and used few gestures, but his message caused near-hysteria in his listeners. In this excerpt from the sermon, after threatening his audience with damnation, Edwards offers them a chance to be saved. How do you think Edwards's listeners responded to his words of hope?

PRIMARY SOURCE

And now you have an extraordinary opportunity, a day wherein Christ has thrown the door of mercy wide open, and stands in the door calling and crying with a loud voice to poor sinners. How awful is it to be left behind at such a day! To see so many rejoicing and singing for joy of heart, while you have cause to mourn for sorrow of heart. How can you rest one moment in such a condition? Therefore let every one that is out of Christ [that has not accepted Christ], now awake and fly from the wrath [fury] to come.

–from "Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God," by Jonathan Edwards, 1741

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.



Church of England minister George Whitefield appealed to many races and classes with his promise of a more equal, or egalitarian, relationship between believers and their God. Here, artist John Collet portrays a meeting during one of Whitefield's seven visits to the colonies. The painting dates to the mid-1700s.

connect with God. Even more dangerously, they began to challenge authority and think themselves equal to those in power.

THE ENLIGHTENMENT

The Great Awakening was not the only movement that helped pave the way for revolutionary fervor. The intellectual movement known as the **Enlightenment** spread from Great Britain to the colonies in the 1700s. Enlightenment thinkers believed that the "light" of human reason would shatter the "darkness" of ignorance, superstition, and unfair authority. In part, they were influenced by the **Scientific Revolution**, which began in Europe around the mid-1550s and used logical thinking to answer scientific questions. The Enlightenment encouraged people to use logic and ask questions instead of just accepting what religious and political figures told them.

The ideas of **John Locke**, a 17th-century English philosopher, greatly influenced Enlightenment thought. Locke asserted that humans were born free and equal with **natural rights**, or rights such as life or liberty that a person is born with. He also claimed that a leader could rule only with the consent of the people. If a ruler failed to protect the people's rights, Locke believed they had the right to overthrow him.

These ideas would prove hugely influential in the colonies. American Enlightenment leaders included Benjamin Franklin, who devoted his life to public service and science. In time, Franklin and many other American founders would start to demand their own rights and freedoms.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was the Great Awakening?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What were some of John Locke's beliefs?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** What did the Enlightenment and the Great Awakening contribute to colonial views about equality and government?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.